

Sprawled across a 4 sq km-area, it had carriage and wagon shops as well as locomotive shops.

Centres of learning

Innovative machinery and equipment were produced, but were all made by European engineers. Canadian historian Ian J Kerr, in his book *Engines of Change*, noted that workshops were “early centres of the heavy engineering industry in India” and “crucibles of technology transfer.”

While certain railway companies such as East Indian Railway (EIR) ran apprenticeship programmes especially for Europeans, Eurasians, and some Indians, the native population, which made up most of the workforce, were generally confined to lower-ranking jobs. Skilled, managerial, and technical positions were mostly reserved for Europeans and Eurasians. The demand to Indianize the railways went up during the Independence movement but was fulfilled only after 1947.

Buy British

Showing a marked indifference towards industrial development in the country, the Government imported everything from Britain – financial capital to build the railways, rails and fishplates for the lines, and machinery for shops to locomotives, skilled labour, and even complete bridges. An apt example of this was seen in the Government’s policy towards the purchase of locomotives.

Nearly 80 per cent of the 14,420 imported locomotives came from Britain. In fact, Vulcan Foundry (which supplied India its first locomotive), along with Beyer, Peacock and Company and North British Locomotive Company– all British companies – looked at India as their primary market. This, despite railway workshops building locomotives from as early as 1865, beginning with Byculla in Bombay. The BB&CI would later go on to build 444 locomotives at its Ajmer Workshop, with Jamalpur producing 217.

The Government’s policy was unabashedly aimed at helping British manufacturers, especially towards the end of the 19th century. American historian Daniel R Headrick wrote of manufacturers requesting George Hamilton, the Secretary of State for India (1895–1903), to intervene when there was an increase in the import of American and Canadian